MODULE 2

CHAPTER 6

AI is Really a Change Initiative

AI often enters the conversation as a technology topic. In practice, the results depend much more on people, process, and leadership alignment.

The providers seeing the strongest results treat AI as a business initiative—using it to improve how work gets done across the organization. This chapter explores why organizational readiness matters more than technology sophistication, and how to assess whether your teams, data, and processes are prepared to support AI-driven change.

What You'll Learn

- Why AI adoption is primarily a business and change initiative—not a technology deployment
- How to recognize where "silo friction" can limit AI's impact across your organization
- How to assess your organization's readiness across leadership, data, and change management
- Which management habits allow AI to deliver measurable, lasting value

People Strategy Versus Technology Strategy

Recent research shows a consistent pattern. Organizations that approach AI as a people and process strategy outperform those that treat it mainly as a technology deployment. Most AI efforts do not stall because the models fail. They stall because the organization is not ready to change how work is conducted.

COMMON APPROACH

AI as an IT Rollout

Treated as a technology project. Stays small, experimental. Lacks clear ownership or business metrics. Teams remain unchanged.

vs

HIGH-IMPACT APPROACH

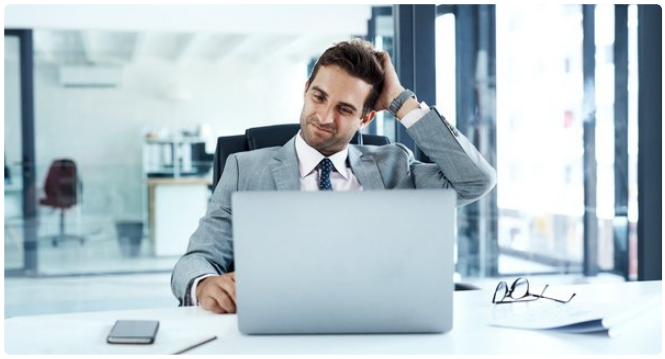
AI as a Business Initiative

Tied to a real performance gap. Clear ownership, clear measures. People and processes evolve alongside the technology. Adoption accelerates.

When AI is treated like an IT rollout, it tends to remain small and experimental. When it is tied to a real performance gap—with clear ownership and measures—adoption accelerates. The difference is not the technology. It is the organizational context surrounding it.

Where AI Efforts Commonly Stall

If the technology is rarely the bottleneck, what is? In most broadband organizations, friction comes from the human and structural side of the equation. Here are the most common friction points that prevent AI from gaining traction:



Teams Don't Trust the Outputs

When teams can't see where AI recommendations come from, they fall back on familiar, manual decisions.

Workflows Remain Unchanged

AI is layered on top of existing processes instead of being integrated into redesigned workflows—creating extra steps rather than removing them.

Data Stays Fragmented

Critical data lives across disconnected systems. Without a unified view, AI can only optimize pieces of the puzzle—not the full picture.

Ownership is Unclear

No single team owns the end-to-end journey. Without clear accountability, AI improvements stall between departments.

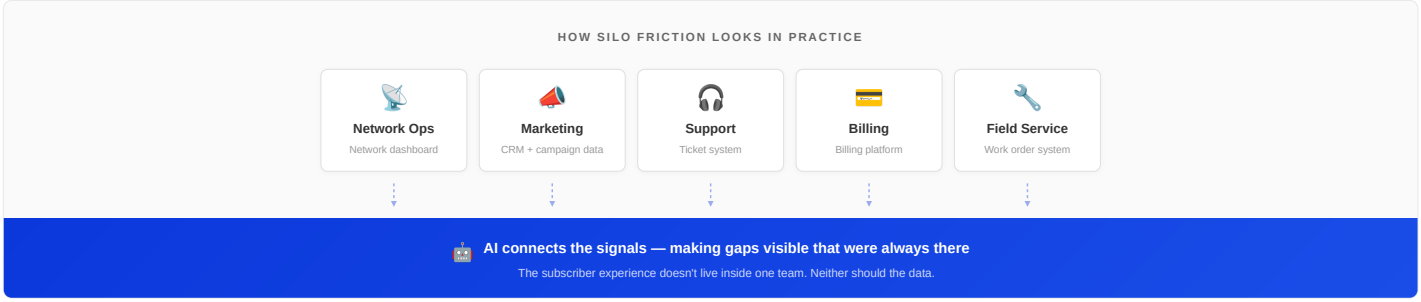
> **The Pattern:** When AI is treated like a technology project, it stays small. When it is tied to a real business outcome—with clear ownership and measures—adoption accelerates and results follow.

Optimizing the End-to-End Subscriber Journey

One of the first things AI exposes inside most broadband organizations is fragmentation. AI agents naturally cut across traditional boundaries, including sales, services, network operations, and back office. This is where "silo friction" shows up. Each team has its own tools, data, and priorities, so the signals needed to manage the subscriber experience are scattered. As AI begins connecting those signals, gaps that were always present become visible—and harder to ignore.

Where Silos Typically Appear

Most organizations have been designed around a command-and-control structure that optimizes work through functional silos with deep expertise. While this structure is effective for scale and control, rarely does any single team have visibility across the end-to-end customer journey. The result? Breakdowns that are invisible to any one department but painfully obvious to your subscribers:



Redesigning against the customer journey exposes one of the most significant change management challenges leaders face: dismantling silos that were never designed to operate as a single system. Instead of asking, "How do we optimize one team's metrics?", high-performing providers ask, "Where does the subscriber experience break down, and how do we catch it earlier?"

Why Journey Thinking Matters

Customers struggle to navigate the inherent delays, friction, miscommunication, and botched handoffs that occur as they interact with your company. They do not care which department owns a particular step—they care whether the experience works. When leadership, data, and processes are aligned on creating a seamless and friction-free experience, it often unlocks meaningful progress that no single team could achieve on its own.

> **Key Insight:** AI does not create silos—but it does make them visible. Use that visibility as a catalyst for the cross-functional alignment your subscriber experience has always needed.

Is Your Organization Ready for AI?

As noted earlier, AI is primarily a change initiative. To successfully implement and scale AI, strong leadership teams assess readiness across three areas. Each one can either accelerate or stall your progress—and the honest assessment of where you stand is more valuable than any technology evaluation.

1 Executive Alignment

> *What problem, if reduced by 20–30%, would most impact outcomes for your organization this year?*

Start with this simple question. Common high-impact problems include declining monthly revenue per subscriber, rising churn risk, growing operating expenses, and slow detection of network issues. Executive alignment means leadership agrees on three things:

- The top priority
- The desired outcome
- How success will be measured

Without this clarity, AI efforts have difficulty moving beyond pilot and fail to deliver a return on investment.

2 Readiness To Adopt

> *Is your data posture strong enough to support AI—even imperfectly?*

Next, assess your data posture in practical terms. Module 3 goes deeper into data strategy, but the key questions to ask now are:

- Are core data sources accessible?
- Are they trusted enough to use?
- Are teams willing to improve data quality where needed?

AI does not require perfect data, but it does require intention and a continuous improvement mindset.

3 Change Management Readiness

> *Are your people prepared for AI to change how work flows across the business?*

AI agents will change workflows across the business. The technology is only as effective as the organization's willingness to adapt. Key leadership questions include:

- Are managers prepared to lead adoption?
- Do teams understand AI is assistive—not a replacement?
- Is there a plan to build confidence over time?

Organizations that prepare people early move faster later.

Remember: These three readiness areas—executive alignment, data posture, and change management—are not sequential. They reinforce each other. Weakness in one area will limit the impact of strength in the others.

Tightening the Management Process

AI is not a "set it and forget it" initiative. It requires oversight and review, and it will amplify whatever management discipline already exists—or doesn't exist. Leaders who build strong operational rhythms around AI see compounding returns. Those who don't will find that AI simply surfaces problems faster than the organization can respond.

Four Habits of High-Readiness Organizations

1 Detect Emerging Realities Early

Rather than waiting for problems to escalate, high-readiness teams use AI signals to identify trends while they are still small and manageable—turning reactive firefighting into proactive stewardship.

2 Manage the System as a Whole

Instead of optimizing individual components in isolation, effective leaders look at how changes in one area ripple across the subscriber journey—managing interconnections, not just individual metrics.

3 Respond Quickly to Small Signals

Small signals, caught early, stay contained. Organizations with strong management rhythms act on early indicators before they compound into systemic issues that require far more effort to resolve.

4 Focus on Creating New Value

Rather than simply shifting work between teams, the most effective organizations use AI to create genuine new value—better subscriber experiences, faster resolution, and proactive engagement.

Leadership must set the tone to get the most out of AI. These four habits are not technology practices—they are management practices. AI simply makes them more visible and more consequential.

Key Insight: AI amplifies whatever management discipline already exists. If your leadership rhythms are strong, AI will make them more effective. If gaps exist, AI will make those visible too. Either way, the clarity is a gift.

Chapter Takeaway

AI does not create change on its own. Instead, it quickly reveals where change is needed. The organizations that move fastest are the ones that treat AI as a business initiative—and prepare their teams, data, and processes to support it. Start with executive alignment on a specific business outcome, assess your readiness honestly, and build the management habits that let AI deliver lasting value.